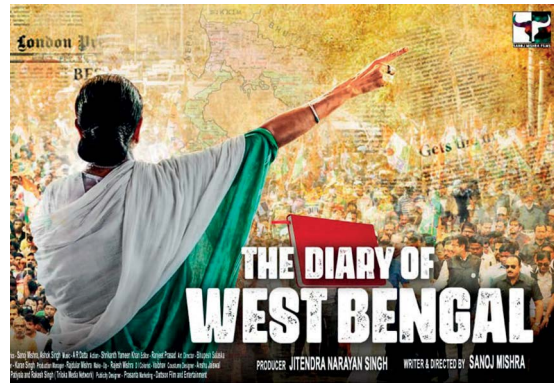
from Noakhali and Sandwip island (in Chittagong, Bangladesh) who migrated to the South 24 Parganas and the Sunderbans long ago," says Maqbul Islam. The BJP demands recognition for the Chowringheenath temple, now lying in an obscure corner of the city's main thoroughfare, J.L. Nehru Road, earlier called Chowringhee Road. A return to the old name must accompany renovation, it says.

There's also a move to change the name of Kolkata's Esplanade to Dharmatala—already the name of a neighbouring area—after the tortoise-shaped (or often aniconic) Dharma deity. Prasad Maharaj, a Hindu priest, points to a huge pond in Dharmatala that has four temple-like structures on its corners. "They could have once served as a Dharma temple. We are trying to revive the religious sanctity of this place by changing the names from Esplanade and Lenin Sarani to Dharmatala and by organising a congregation of one lakh preachers and Gita chanting this year," he says. That the Dharma cult has an umbilical link to castes like the Doms, kept outside the periphery of the varna order or high Puranic Hinduism, is a paradox that homogenising Hindutva breezes over. That's why Prasanta Ray, professor emeritus at Presidency University, calls the BJP's Hindutva a political construct and says, "We cannot locate the Hinduism we know in the BJP's Hinduism."

CALENDAR PROPAGANDA

All this search for new roots goes hand in hand with an old, patented tactic. In 2020, the Hindu Samhati Mancha, a Hindutva outfit, came up with a calendar featuring 12 Sultanate-era structures of Bengal, one for each month, that were allegedly built after razing Hindu landmarks. Each page had a snapshot of the structure's pre-Islamic 'history'. For example, recalling the P.N. Oak-style rebranding of Delhi's Qutub Minar, it styles the Pandua Minar in Hooghly, a tower said to commemorate the victory of military leaders Sufiuddin and Sharafuddin over a local Hindu king, as a 'Shakti Peetha'. Similarly, it claims the Adina Masjid in Malda came up on the site of a demolished Adinath temple in 1368. Debtanu Bhattacharya of the Mancha says the calendar aims to create "awareness". Asked if there are plans to rebuild or restore temples on these sites, he was diplomatic. "Sanatan dharma talks of universal humanism but...the majoritarian mood we see today is the outburst of suppressed emotions for being victims of aggression," he says.



***THE DIARY OF WEST BENGAL* IS ABOUT 'MINORITY APPEASEMENT' BY THE TMC. ITS PROTAGONIST IS STYLED AFTER MAMATA**

Beyond this, the BJP has decided to embrace and sponsor not just big Durga and Kali pujas, many of which are largely under Trinamool control, but hyperlocal ones like the pujas to Rakkhya Kali and Ratanti Kali in Hooghly, Sraboni mela in Tarakeswar, the Chaitra Sankranti Gajan mela in Malda, those related to the Poush and Makar Sankrantis, and the Tusu-Bhadu and Hul utsavs of various castes, tribal groups and the Rajbongshis of north Bengal. The RSS has been making inroads into Rajbongshi spaces with sangkirtans. "We are targeting Dalits and Adivasis who often cohabit with Muslims," says a party leader. "With our association, we give them a feeling of being under our protective wings." DJ boxes become part of the inventory of assertion in such spaces. But often enough, this activation of the field is accomplished at one remove. "Our leadership wants us to explore the rural constituencies. But we don't come in the picture directly. Small local groups and NGOs organise festivals, sports events, picnics and such like. We offer sponsorship and other assistance," says the leader.

CINEMATIC SAFFRON

Related to this propagandist surge, several films are primed to further the BJP's agenda in Bengal. Written and produced by Jitendra Narayan Singh, *The Diary of West Bengal* talks of the displacement of Hindus in the face of "minority appeasement" by the TMC. The trailer highlights clips where the protagonist, styled after Mamata with no pretension to allegorical finesse, mouths her popular *khela hobe* ('game's on') slogan. And a film on the 'great Calcutta killing' of August 1946 is expected to be directed by Vivek Agnihotri of *Kashmir Files* fame. A film on 'Gopal Patha' or Gopal Chandra Mukhopadhyay, who played a significant role by saving Hindus on Direct Action Day in August 1946, is also in the works—posing the question, as it were, on why a man who should have been considered a Hindu icon was forced into oblivion by successive governments of Bengal. Expect many of these questions—from culture and religion—to be swirling in the air as Bengal inches closer to the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, where the central BJP is eyeing half of its 42 seats. ■